

Termination TRAUMA

A prestigious institution turns into a killing field of ambition as it expels 43 students on grounds of poor academic performance



Photographs by LALU CHAUHAN

By Farzand Ahmed |

That President Pratibha Patil buried a time capsule celebrating 50 glorious years of the Indian Institute of Technology, Kanpur (IIT-K), on March 6 was an irony not lost on a group of students sitting in a coffee house just outside the campus. The President had preserved for posterity a record of the institution's achievements, and the students belonged to a group of 43 who had been expelled by the institute this year from a batch of 250. As congratulatory speeches were made at the function, the coffee house group sang songs of hope.

Hope is all that these students, most from the Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes (SC/ST), now have. Says Sandeep Pandey, Magsaysay

award-winning social activist and former IIT-K faculty member, "It's strange that during its golden jubilee year such a large number of students are crushed by the system. This puts a question mark on the relevance of the institute."

The problem started in mid-January when IIT-K authorities decided to terminate 43 undergraduate and postgraduate students, barring them from taking semester examinations on grounds of poor academic performance. The terminated students do not see poor academic performance as the only reason. A month before the celebra-

tion, a group of students led by Vijay Narayan Pal, an IIT-K alumnus, launched a mass contact campaign in protest. Vikas Pankaj, a terminated student, says that while the IIT-K system has proved to be a "career killer", it is the first time that some students have raised the issue at the national level. Every semester, 10-12 students are terminated, but this year saw the highest number. Termination is not uncommon at other IITs but the numbers are not as large.

Pal, who teaches mathematics at the nearby Chhatrapati Shahuji Maharaj University, Kanpur, has become a local guardian for the

“Only those who don't meet academic requirements are barred from examinations.”

SANJEEV S. KASHALKAR, IIT-K Registrar

